

Instead, you use a virtual machine that takes care of all of your needs. It's a pre-packaged Vagrant box which provides the entire development environment without the hassles. The simplicity of it is just delightful. You get a gamut of applications like Nginx web server, PHP 7.2, PHP 7.1, PHP 7.0, PHP 5.6, MySQL, PostgreSQL, Redis, Memcached, Node and more at just the click of a button. On top of that, it's cross platform and runs on Windows, Mac or Linux systems.

Vagrant builds and manages virtual machine environments. To use it, you need to also install a virtualization application like VirtualBox 5.2 or VMWare or Parallels or Hyper-V. Some of them are free, some are paid. Once you have these up and running, you are ready to roll.

Installing & Configuring Homestead

Open the terminal and enter in the command `vagrant box add laravel/homestead`. This will add the additional `laravel/homestead` box to the Vagrant installation. Once the box is downloaded, you can install Homestead by cloning the repository. Clone it into a Homestead folder within your "home" directory. All of your Laravel projects will be hosted out of this directory. Enter the command `git clone https://github.com/laravel/homestead.git ~/Homestead`. Read through the documentation on the Github release page to find out the latest stable version. Once you have the version, change the directory to Homestead (`cd ~/Homestead`) and clone the desired version (`git checkout v7.2.0`).

Now you need to create the configuration file named `Homestead.yaml` which will then be placed in the Homestead directory. To do this, you need to run the `bash init.sh` command if you are using Mac or Linux or `init.bat` if you are using Windows. Set your virtualization machine that you have installed by typing `provider: virtualbox` in the terminal.

Next you will want to set up your directory and list the folders you want to share with the virtual Homestead environment.

Map a folder with the command-

```
- map: ~/code/project1
    to: /home/vagrant/code/project
```

Now the folder `Project1` is synced with your local machine and the homestead environment. Synced folders can cause performance issues. You can eliminate this by enabling NFS by adding a flag: `type: "nfs"`. Windows users, a piece of bad news- NFS does not work on Windows, so